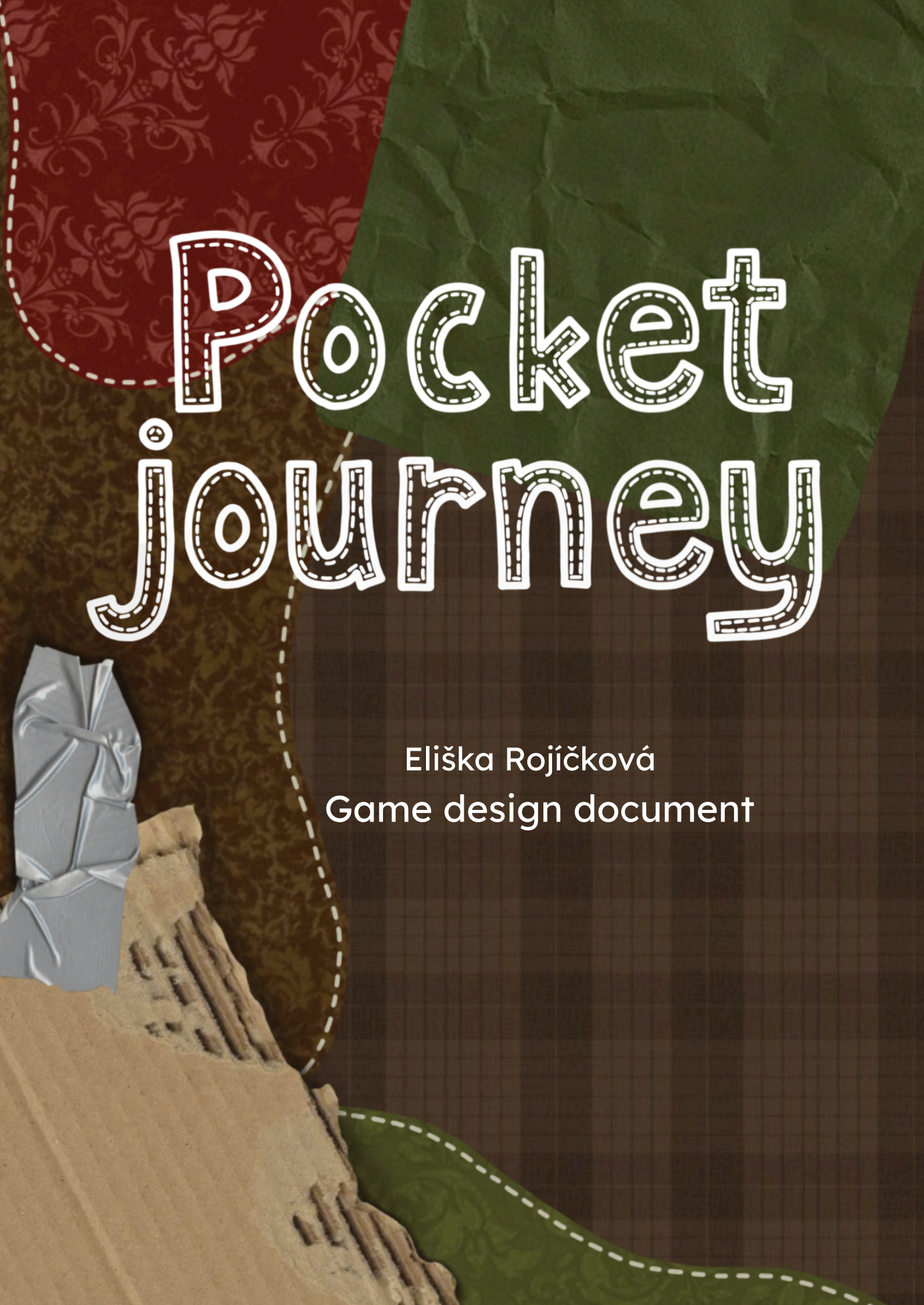




Pocket journey

Eliška Rojíčková
Game design document

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Overview

Pocket Journey is a 2D adventure where the player controls a small elf who has fallen into a coat pocket. The aim is to navigate through the inside of the coat, find a way through a hole in the pocket, and eventually reach the second pocket and escape. Players will encounter various everyday objects throughout the game, which serve as obstacles or challenges because of the elf's small size. Players must solve puzzles by collecting items and combining them to craft new tools. The game turns ordinary pocket contents into unique gameplay elements.

Genre and platform

It is a 2D point-and-click puzzle game. It will be available on PC.

Feature list

1. Puzzle mechanics
2. Pickable objects
3. Interactive objects
4. Inventory system
5. Crafting system
6. NPC interaction
7. Boss puzzle
8. Arcade and puzzle minigames

Core Loop

The main player's actions are movement through the level, interacting with objects, picking objects and crafting new items from them.

Player's movement

The player moves using the WSAD keys. The camera follows the player. The level is divided into different 'rooms', the player has to use doors and other access points, such as holes, to travel between them.

Pickable objects

In each level, there are several pickable objects. Though some are quite unusual, they are all objects that someone might forget in a coat pocket. The player can pick them up when he is near them and after that, they appear in the inventory bar on the top of the screen. The player has to pick up all the pickable objects to solve the puzzles and continue.

Crafting

Crafting is accessible via the inventory bar. The player can craft new a object easily by dragging one object on top of the other. Every new object has to be made of two objects. Sometimes player has to create a few intermediate objects to reach the final product. Because the objects which the player finds can not be collected more than once, the player can always craft just the things which help him on the way and it is not possible to use some object to craft anything which leads to a dead end.

Interactive objects

Some objects in the level are interactive. The interaction is done by clicking the mouse. The player has to be near the object for the interaction. Some interactions require the player to have the item in the inventory which he will use for the interaction. (For example, having the crowbar for opening the doors). Other examples of interactive objects are buttons, levers, drawers, various types of objects which the player can break, so he can collect just a part of it for crafting and more.

Reward after action

After the player finishes the level, he moves further in the story and on his way out of the coat world. The player collects items along the way that help them progress further; some items can only be used once, while others can be used multiple times, making the rest of the journey easier.

Extended

Interaction with NPCs

Sometimes the player can meet with some NPS. There are creatures living in the coat pocket. They can help him on the way by giving the player some useful item or sometimes they are not happy, that someone is in their territory, so the player has to figure out how to bypass them.

Bosses

At the end of every section, which contains multiple levels, the player has to face the boss. It will not be combat, but more like a puzzle-based fight, where the player has to figure out how he has to use the environment and the items to defeat the boss or more likely bypass the boss and sneak into the next section. If the player fails, he goes to 'prison' (it does not necessarily look like a prison visually) from where he has to first escape to try to defeat the boss again.

Minigames

Sometimes there will be a minigame that the player has to win to continue in a game. It could be an arcade game or some puzzle game. The minigame will appear as an extra window which overlays the game. There will be two ways in which the player encounters the minigame. First, the player will be using some machine to play the game on, and after winning it will open the door or drop some objects for example. The second way is that he will have to defeat some NPC in that minigame.

Wish

Interactive storyline

There will be few options in the game where the player can decide what to do and all the way will somehow lead to the end, but the journey will be different and the player will have to overcome different obstacles on the way. This game mechanic would further emphasize the idea that the world inside the coat pocket isn't entirely linear, and the player might occasionally return to places they've already visited. However, with new items they've collected, they'd be able to access areas that were previously unreachable.

Minimum viable prototype plan

The minimum viable prototype plan is to have one finished level, where the player can try the main mechanics: interaction with objects, crafting, interactive interface in the game, and moving through access points to different rooms. The main puzzle element in that level will be the possibility of changing the light in the room, which will be the key to finishing this level. The total cost for the minimum viable prototype is a 49 days.

Tickets

Player movement

A player can walk around the map using WSAD

- [Code] Player walk (2)
- [Art] Player walk animation (1)
- [Sound] Walking sound (1)

Climbing ladders

A player can climb on ladders.

- [Code] Player can climb the ladder i.e. move vertically in certain spots. The player can change the direction (from up to down and otherwise) during the climbing. (2)
- [Art] Animation of player climbing the ladder. (1)
- [Sound] Sound of climbing a ladder. (1)

Moving through an access point

The player can move through an access point to another part of the map and back.

- [Code] Player moves to another 'room' when he is near the access point and clicks on it. (1)

Interactive objects - general

A player can interact with some objects. In level 1, there will be a switch in room 1 that the player can use to control the room's light.

- [Code] Highlighting appears when the player is nearby. (2)
- [Code] By clicking on the interactive object the function for interaction is run. (1)
- [Art] Highlighting for each object. (1)

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Interactive objects - interaction with item

A player can interact with a special object when he has in inventory an item which is needed for the interaction. In level 1 there will be a mechanical control panel for the big door (blue in the level 1 sketch), player needs a steering wheel (made out of a button and a match) to open that door.

- [Code] Check if the player has the object needed for the interaction. (1)
- [Code] Deleting the object from the inventory if the object is only for one use. (1)
- [Code] For level 1 - opening the door (1)
- [Art] For level 1 - animation of opening the door by using the steering wheel (2)

Interactive interface - direction lock

The player can open an interactive interface in the game with a direction lock. There is a small knob with which the player can move in four directions (up, down, left, right) There are also buttons for restart and confirmation. The player has to do a certain sequence of movements, after each move, the knob automatically returns to the centre, and then press the button for confirmation.

- [Code] Opening the interface by clicking on the interface panel. (1)
- [Code] Movement of the knob, entering the code by movement. (2)
- [Code] Buttons for restart and confirmation. (1)
- [Art] The interface (2)
- [Sound] Sound effect for correct and incorrect code. (1)

Picking objects

A player can pick a pickable object. In level 1 the player can pick a match and a button.

- [Code] Object will disappear from the world (1)
- [Code] Object will appear in the inventory (1)
- [Art] Assets for the objects. (1)

Inventory system

There will be inventory on the top edge of the screen. The player can see there the items which he has.

- [Code] Displaying the items which the player has in his inventory. (1)
- [Art] Background for the inventory. (1)

Crafting

The player can craft items from different objects in his inventory. For level 1 it will be crafting steering wheel from a match and button.

- [Code] Player can drag one item on top of the other to craft a new item. Old items will disappear from the inventory because they are used. (2)
- [Code] The new item will be only crafted when the correct items are dragged, but it does not matter if object A is dragged on object B or B on A. (2)
- [Art] Asset of the new item. (1)

Changing the room lighting

The player can change the room lighting via some interactive object (switch). When the light changes, images and shapes appear on the wall, which helps the player to solve the puzzle.

- [Code] Show/hide the images after the interaction. (2)
- [Art] The images (2)

Basic UI

Basic UI which allows the user to pause the level, resume, restart or quit the game. It will appear on pressing the escape button, so the UI will not disturb the player.

- [Code] Showing the UI on key press. (1)
- [Code] Pause the level, resume, restart and quit game buttons (1)
- [Art] The UI, mostly the buttons. (1)

Level design

Design of the first level. Where the player can try some of the main mechanics.

- [Level design] Designing the level (3)
- [Art] All the assets shown in the level (4)

Description of level 1:

Room 0:

- The player spawns there. There is a match to pick, access point to room 1 (access point to room 2 is not visible at the beginning) big door with its panel and interactive interface.
- The player has to go to room 1.

Room 1:

- There is a switch, which changes the light in the rooms (every room in this level) and shows some icons on the wall.

Room 0:

- Back in room 0, there are also icons (arrows) on the wall when the light is changed. The player has to use this combination of directions for the direction lock in the interactive interface. The correct sequence of movement in the direction lock open access point 2.

Room 2:

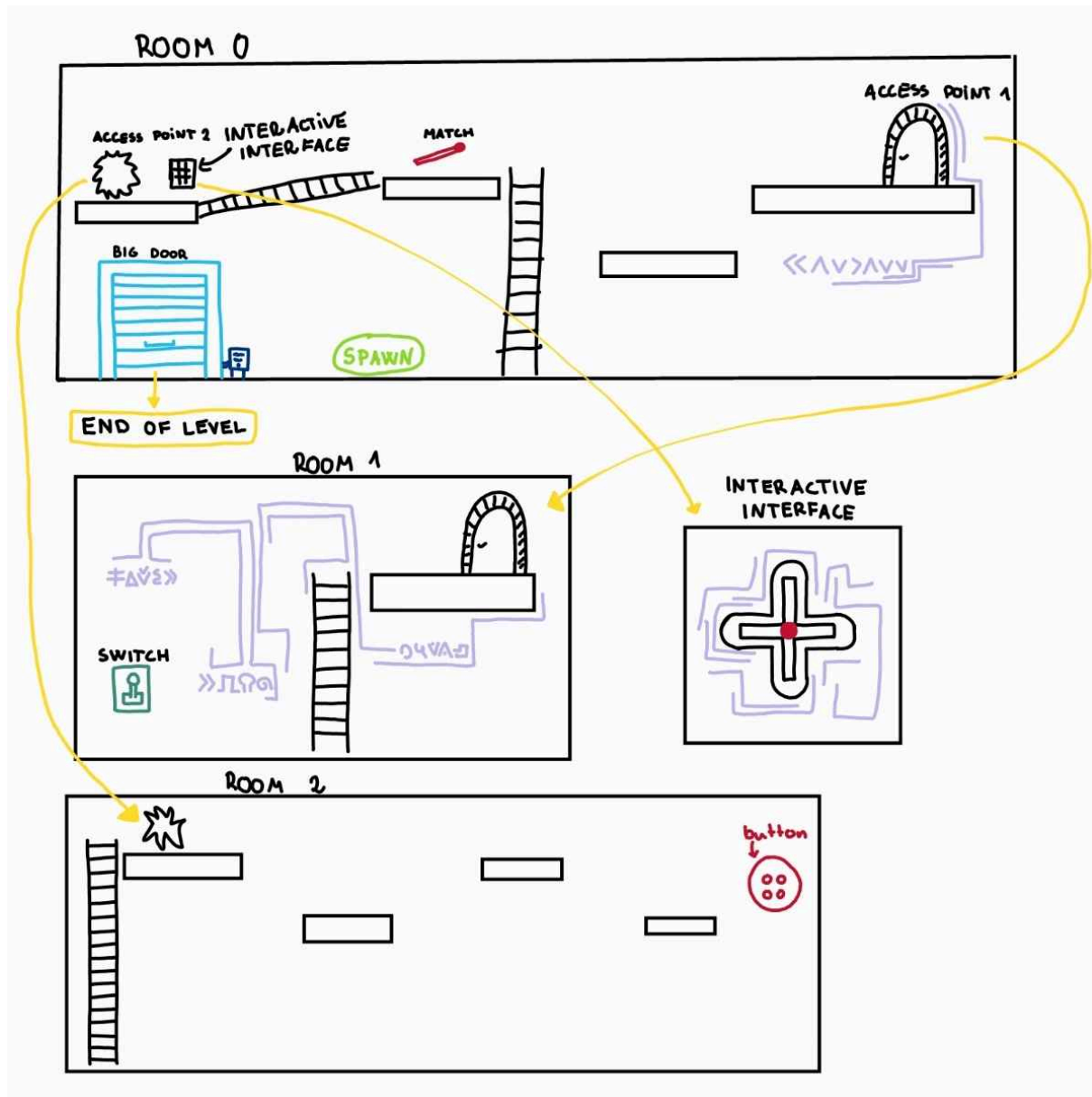
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- In room 2, after the player jumps over obstacles, he can pick a button.

Room 0:

- The player can pick there a match, and craft a steering wheel from it and the button. With that, he can open the big door and finish the level.



Sketch of level 1

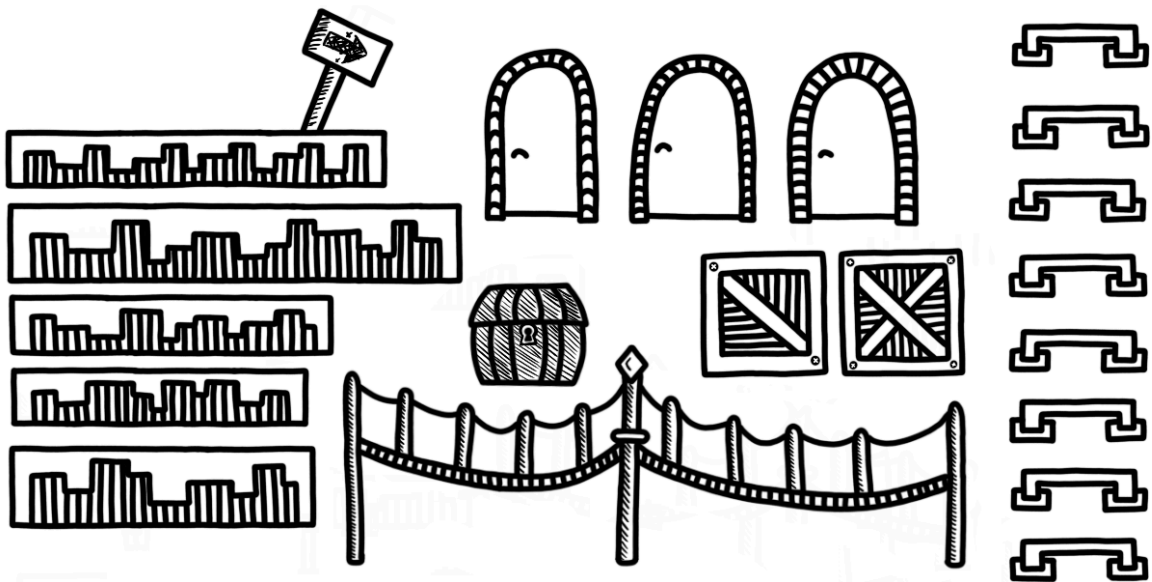
Future Team

I would like to work on this game in a team of four or five. Two people mostly focused on programming, one person focused on level design and one person focused on art, while some of them would be focused on music as well, or there will be another person for that. My role would be the level designer combined with helping the artist with the art.

Art style

The art style of this game is a combination of collage and hand-drawn elements. The background is a collage of several different materials, resembling patchwork made from various patterned fabrics and old paper. When the player travels to another room through the access point, the background of that place will be very similar to the fabric on which was the access point, so it will look like it is just a pocket in that piece of fabric.

The interactive objects and platforms are simple black-line art that pops up on the background collage so that the player can distinguish them easily. The pickable items are a combination of both styles, a photo of an existing object with a black outline. The inventory will be drawn in the black-line art style and located on the edge of the screen so that it won't interfere with the game.



Some examples of blackline platforms and interactive objects.

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An example of the game with the inventory on top is.



Example of some pickable items.

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Cutscenes

There will be a cutscene at the beginning of the game which will show the player how the elf falls into the pocket and then through the hole at the bottom of the pocket to the new world in the coat. The cutscene will smoothly transition directly to the first level, where the player will start. During the game, there will be more cutscenes, but there will be just short ones, mostly when the player meets some interesting NPCs or puzzle elements.

Audio

The music style will be acoustic folk evoking cozy and homemade feeling. The main instruments will be acoustic guitar combined with ukulele, light percussion and gentle piano melodies. There will be sound effects for different interaction with objects and the environment.